COURSEWORK SPECIFICATION
ECM3401 – Individual Project and Literature Review
Module Leader: **Dr Zeliang Wang**
Academic Year: 2025/26

Title: **Literature Review and Project Plan**

Submission deadline: **12pm, 18th November 2025**

This assessment contributes **20%** of the total module mark and **will allow you to demonstrate what you have learned** by assessing the following **intended learning outcomes**:

- Master writing styles appropriate to both a theoretical discursive document and technical report, including use of tables and figures and good referencing practice.
- Undertake independent research in a chosen topic, summarise findings and provide critical analysis.

How can feedback help you improve your work?

- For those who took ECM2417 Outside the Box: Computer Science Research and Applications, the assessment feedback you received in ECM2427 offers valuable guidance to strengthen your literature review for the current project.
- The feedback from this assessment will help you identify research gaps, as well as any risks and ethical considerations within your chosen project topic. It will support the development of project aims and work plan, the consolidation of your intellectual contributions, and the strengthening of methodological rigour in addressing your research questions or software design challenges. These insights will offer constructive suggestions to aid your preparation for the final report and project demonstration assessments.

Plagiarism

This is an individual assessment.

Plagiarism is interpreted by the university as the act of presenting the work of others as one's own work, without acknowledgement. It is considered academically fraudulent and an offence against university discipline. Your attention is drawn to the university's regulations on plagiarism.

Generative AI

This assessment falls under the category of **AI-Assisted** in the University's Guidance on use of GenAI in Assessment.

This is because using AI tools in specific ways can assist with your learning and will not inhibit fair assessment of your achievement of the module's intended learning outcomes.

This means: You may use GenAI tools ethically and responsibly to assist in the development of an assessment in accordance with the boxes checked below.

☒ *To develop ideas*

☒ *To assist with research or information gathering*

☒ *To help you understand key concepts and theories*

☒ *To identify trends and themes as part of data analysis*

☒ *To provide feedback on a draft*

☒ *To improve the plan or structure of my assessment*

☒ *To identify trends and themes as part of data analysis*

☒ *To generate images, figures or diagrams*

☒ *To proofread and correct spelling or grammar errors*

☒ *To format citations or references*

☒ *To translate material into English*

When *writing* your assessment, you must never use AI tools:

1. For uses other than those represented by checked boxes in the list above.
2. To upload sensitive or identifying material to an AI tool
3. To present material that has been generated by AI as your own work or the work of someone else.

When *submitting* your assessment, you must:

1. Check the box during the submission process, that confirms you have adhered to the university's academic conduct policy and the expectations on use of GenAI in your assessment brief.
2. Treat the AI tool like a citation from any other source.
3. Include a list of all AI prompts and hyperlinks to their output with your references, at the end of your work. You do not need to include the outputs themselves, just the links.

4. Verify your reference list to ensure that all sources cited are genuine and accurately documented (i.e., no fabricated references in your work).

5. Retain the full outputs generated by the prompts you have used during your assignment. These outputs should be accessible at the hyperlinks which you have submitted with your assignment. You may be asked to produce this material in the event of an academic conduct inquiry.

Instructions

You must produce an **8-page** report covering the preliminary research you have done to prepare yourself for undertaking your project, together with an initial specification for the project itself.

"Research" here means reading, analysing and comparing existing material that is relevant to your project topic, and providing a reasoned summary of your findings.

The kind of material you consult will depend on the nature of your topic. Typically, your project will involve both an external subject area and various computational methods or resources that you will apply to that area (e.g., if you are devising a system for handwriting recognition, you will need to research how humans read and write as well as the computational pattern recognition or image processing tools you will be using). The sources you use may include books, journals, conference papers, web pages, and existing software. All of these will need to be referenced in a correct and consistent style, with the references collected together in bibliography at the end of the document.

The project aims, objectives and deliverables should be defined explicitly. You should provide clear criteria for evaluating the final product and results, i.e., what will count as a successful outcome for your project.

Your submission must comprise three parts, as follows:

1. A separate **title page** containing your name, a 100-200 word abstract.

2. The **body**, which must be no more than **8-page (i.e., 8 sides of A4)** and presented with **11pt font** with **margins of 2cm** (single column, single line-spacing). A **5-mark deduction** will be applied for each page by which the length of the document (excluding the title page and references) exceeds 8 pages.

3. The **bibliography**, also in a font not less than 11 pt. It is expected that this section will take up at least half a side of A4, and is not likely to exceed three sides.

You must submit your work to ELE2 by the submission deadline provided on the cover of this document.

Please see overleaf for marking criteria.

	Literature Review (60%)	Project Plan (30%)	Style (10%)
Fail (0-39%)	• Very little work is reviewed and there is no depth or breadth. • No critical analysis has been attempted. • There are few or no references included, and they are not of appropriate quality. • No gaps in the literature have been identified.	• Aims and objectives are minimal or missing. • There is little or no detail in the description of work. Major queries remain about the approach to be taken in the project. • No time plan is provided for the project. • There is no discussion of either risk or ethics.	• The basic style guidance has not been followed. • Writing style is extremely poor and material cannot be understood. • No bibliography has been provided.
3rd (40-49%)	• Some relevant existing work is reviewed but there is little depth or breadth. • Very little critical analysis. The text is very descriptive. • There are some references but they are from unreliable sources and are not up-to-date. • Limited gaps in the literature are identified and there are no suggestions about how they might be addressed.	• Aims and objectives are confused and unclear with little significant gaps relating to the project described. • There is little detail in the description of work and the approach to be taken is unclear. • A basic time plan is provided. More detail is needed. • Limited discussion of either risk or ethics.	• There has been an attempt to follow the style guidance but with major omissions. • Writing style is poor – major parts cannot be understood. • Basic bibliography – poorly formatted and with major omissions.
2:2 (50-59%)	• The review has breadth of the area but one or two major omissions. There is little depth. • Critical analysis is attempted but is lacking. • A range of references are used but they may be either from unreliable sources or are not up-to-date. • Some gaps are identified in the state-of-the-art but are limited. Very few suggested approaches to address them.	• Aims and objectives provide a reasonable overview of the project but lack detail. • One or more major omissions in the description of work leading to questions about what will be done in the project. • Reasonable time plan but does not highlight deliverables, milestones or account for stretch goals or slippage. • Reasonable discussion of either risk or ethics (lacking minor details).	• Some of the style guidance is followed but there are omissions. • Writing style hinders understanding in some parts. • Bibliography is incomplete and references are missing important details.
2:1 (60-69%)	• The review of the area covers most important areas with some minor omissions. Most areas are covered in sufficient depth. • Reasonable critical analysis identifies weaknesses in current approaches. • Mostly reliable and up-to-date sources are uses. • Some gaps are identified in the state-of-the-art but limited approaches suggested to address them.	• Aims and objectives mostly cover the project described. Clarity and presentation could be enhanced. Objectives are not measurable or prioritised. • The description has slight gaps in detail. • Time plan missing one or two details. Deliverables and milestones highlighted but stretch goals and slippage time are not accounted for. • Risk and ethics are considered but lacking in some minor details.	• Style guidance mostly followed. • Written material easy to follow but minor points could be clarified. • Bibliography is missing minor details for some references.

	Literature Review (60%)	Project Plan (30%)	Style (10%)
1st (70-79%)	• A comprehensive review of the area is presented with ideas discussed in depth. • Excellent critical analysis of the existing work in the field. • An excellent range of reliable and up-to-date sources are used. • The review identifies appropriate gaps in the state-of-the-art and proposes approaches to addressing them.	• Project aims and objectives are complete, clearly presented and precise. Objectives are measurable and prioritised. • The work to be undertaken is clear and comprehensively described. • The project has been organised into a sensible time plan that includes stretch goals, slippage time, deliverables and milestones. • Detailed consideration of risk and ethics is made.	• Style guidance followed completely. • Writing style is clear and concise with few (if any) typos/errors. • Bibliography is complete and correct.
1st (80-100%)	• An exceptionally comprehensive review of the area is presented, showing not only depth but also the ability to synthesise complex ideas into a cohesive narrative. • Outstanding critical analysis that demonstrates original thought, with a deep and nuanced critique of the existing work and their limitations. • An exceptional range of authoritative sources are used, showcasing a deep engagement with the latest research. • The review not only identifies gaps in the literature but also proposes highly innovative and viable approaches for addressing these gaps, demonstrating intellectual independence and creativity.	• Project aims and objectives are exceptionally comprehensive and articulately defined. Objectives are not only measurable and prioritised but also clearly aligned with project challenges. • The work to be undertaken is extensively detailed, demonstrating a deep understanding of the project scope and employing innovative methodologies. • The project plan is expertly structured, showcasing a detailed timeline that includes stretch goals, slippage time, along with deliverables and milestones. • Extensive consideration of risk and ethical implications is provided, reflecting a proactive and nuanced approach to potential challenges.	• Style guidance followed completely. • Writing style is clear and concise with no typos/errors. • Bibliography is complete and correct. • The style and presentation should meet a quality level suitable for publication in a reputable conference or journal.